

**Regular Meeting
Monday, May 6, 2019
Medford School Committee
Council Chambers**

Present: Ms. DiBenedetto, Ms. Kreatz, Ms. Mustone, Mr. Ruggiero, Mr. Ruseau, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke, Superintendent Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent, Associate Superintendent Diane Caldwell, Assistant Superintendent Kirsteen Patterson.

Roll Call and Salute the Flag - Meeting called to order at 7:10PM.

Approval of Minutes of April 8, 2019 - Motion to approve offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Kreatz, motion granted.

Approval of Bills/Transfer of Funds and Approval of Payrolls - Motion to approve offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Ms. Kreatz. Roll call vote.

7 affirmative

0 negative

Motion passes.

Motion for suspension of the rules to take item 4 out of order offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Ms. Mustone, motion granted.

Recognition of Student Achievements: Humanities Awards - Dr. Nicole Chiesa - Certificates were presented to students for three achievements in the Humanities: Model United Nations, The Bostonian Society and Boston Duck Tour 2019 Essay Contest, and NPR Student Podcast Challenge - Mayor Burke presented certificates to students. Dr. Chiesa - We are very proud of our students. Please join me in congratulating the exceptional writer and historian Teagan Mustone who won the Duck Tour Essay Contest two years in a row! Congratulations to all.

Recognition of Christine Hingston, Recipient of MATSOL's Teacher of the Year Award - Diane Caldwell - Congratulations to Christine for her well-deserved award. Ms. Hingston - Thank you to the teachers at the Roberts School for supporting me, for putting together evidence of my work, it shows what kind of people are at the school. Thank you to Mr. Johnson for his support.

Motion to revert to regular schedule offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Mr. Ruseau, motion carries.

Community Participation - Maureen Ronayne - I have a second grader in the district who has been diagnosed with dyslexia. We were told he tested well and was bored in lessons. We had him tested in other locations and they noted that he tested poorly and needed more intervention. An attorney told me that the district's program does not meet federal guidelines. Please make dyslexia a priority in professional development. The schools fight against diagnosing dyslexia.

Mr. Ruggiero - I have heard this story from other families as well. I would like to request a report on dyslexia in the district. Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Tonight we have Dr. Nadine Gaab to discuss the science of dyslexia. We can not discuss particular students. I would defer to our Director of Pupil Services for the exact numbers. Ms. DiBenedetto - Thank you to Ms. Ronayne for coming forward. Ms. Van der Kloot - My youngest is dyslexic and we did not know until she was much older.

Motion to take papers 2 and 3 out of order offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

Mayor Burke - My own child was diagnosed with dyslexia as well, it took a special teacher to notice it and thank you for our hard working teachers.

Report on the Science of Dyslexia - Dr. Nadine Gaab - When the transition begins from learning to read to reading to learn, if a student is not reading on their own at the end of second grade and the beginning of third grade, teachers stop teaching specifics of learning to read and it can have effects on a child's social life and emotional health. The National Center for Education Statistics report card has shown no improvement in student reading outcomes, it remains below proficient level. All interventions we know about for dyslexia also work for students who do not have dyslexia but have a different reading disability. The Dyslexia Paradox: Dyslexia is generally diagnosed after the most effective intervention window. Intervention usually begins in third grade, after the most useful window. Kindergarten and first grade is the best time to intervene for dyslexia. There are behavioral predictors of dyslexia. The brain alterations show up in preschool, prior to Kindergarten. Solving the paradox involves a paradigm shift. The new law in Massachusetts requires early risk screening in Kindergarten. The idea is not to put all the children in special education. The idea is that the children and teachers know who is at risk to develop reading disabilities and then when they reach third grade, they have not developed a reading disability. In order to be compliant with the law this coming fall, districts need to follow recommendations in the screen to intervene model. It ends up requiring less intervention and better outcomes. The Department of Elementary and Secondary Education is working on developing guidelines to be in compliance but I recommend that districts prepare ahead. Mr. Ruggiero - Of the 10% of the students who are dyslexic, what percentage have a medical diagnosis of dyslexia? Dr. Gaab - They would all have a diagnosis. There would also be students

not reading at grade level for other reasons on top of that. Mr. Ruggiero - What should we do about the students in sixth grade who have missed the window for intervention? Dr. Gaab - They should receive intervention for their difficulties at any age, but it is easiest when they are youngest. The iPad diagnosis requires no training for teachers, it is in the early stages of development and not yet available, but it would take about 15-20 minutes to take the assessment. Ms. Van der Kloot - Is this something that can be seen even before preschool for parents? Dr. Gaab - The screeners are usually for preschool and early kindergarten. You can implement in general education. I can look into which districts are doing well. We are moving toward a preventive model which is better for mental health and academic outcomes for students. Ms. DiBenedetto - How can we get you to work with our district? Dr. Gaab - I can share a list of resources with you. Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Dr. Gaab also did a robust professional development session with our administrators in the district which will help us address the mandate coming down from the state level.

Motion to investigate dyslexia consultants and offer pricing options during the current budget process offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot and Mr. Ruggiero, motion passes.

Ms. Kreatz - Is dyslexia curable? Dr. Gaab - Yes. Students can overcome reading deficiencies.

Report on Medford's Response to Dyslexia Screening Law - Dr. Nicole Chiesa, Katie Ciampoli, and Suzannah Campbell - Dr. Chiesa - The Dyslexia Screening Law requires that the Department of Elementary and Secondary Education in conjunction with the Department of Early Education and Care develop guidelines to assist schools in developing screening procedures or protocols for students with reading disabilities. The district is awaiting those guidelines from DESE. In the meantime, the district has engaged administrators and teachers in professional development. The district has also established a Dyslexia Screening Law Task Force to anticipate the DESE guidelines. The district has proactively implemented a universal screener for school year 2019-2020. All students in grades kindergarten through second will be screened using the *Shaywitz DyslexiaScreen* program. Mr. Ruseau - We are not necessarily being proactive. We are being proactive about the law, not about helping students read. We should be teaching phonics. After doing this, if teachers need to teach phonics, what are we going to do about the teachers that refuse to teach it? Dr. Edouard-Vincent - You are implying that teachers will be able to opt-out, but that will not be an option. We do not have something formally in place right now, so we are working to put something in place now while we wait for DESE to give official guidelines. It will not be optional. Mr. Ruseau - My point is not about screening. If staff is incapable, disinterested, or not up to par to do it, it is very boring, and we need to make sure it is not a choice. Dr. Chiesa - Fidelity to a program can always be an obstacle. One way we check for fidelity is a collective effort. We do walk-throughs, dedicated time in block schedule at the

elementary level, check-ins, feedback from teachers about what is working, so we can work through the obstacles. If you just put out regulations and people are not trained, lack the motivation, and do not have check-ins, it can be harder to see results. The teachers need to be supported with quality professional development. Ms. DiBenedetto - Can the task force go to Andover Public Schools and view their system? Dr. Chiesa - My children go to school in Andover so I can do that. Ms. DiBenedetto - Can we assess the students for reading when we do assessments before Kindergarten? Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Before we are able to do the best version of this, we are going to at least screen students where they are now. Ms. DiBenedetto - Can we have a cost analysis for the different programs that are available to screen students now? Ms. Mustone - Is the *Shaywitz DyslexiaScreen* program one Dr. Gaab would recommend? Dr. Gaab - No, but there are some that are less expensive and are more effective.

Motion to hold off on purchasing the *Shaywitz DyslexiaScreen* until we have more information offered by Ms. Mustone, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto, motion passes.

Mr. Ruggiero - How many students in the district have dyslexia IEPs? Ms. Ciampoli - I do not know off the top of my head.

Mr. Ruseau - Regardless of screener, the interventions are what is expensive.

Motion to receive this report and place on file offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto, motion passes.

Motion to revert to regular schedule offered by Ms. Mustone, seconded by Ms. Kreatz, motion passes.

Superintendent's Updates and Comments - Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Middle School lottery - We are One Medford, One District. Andrews Middle School open house will be Wednesday, May 8th, 6pm to 8pm. McGlynn Middle School open house will be Tuesday, May 14th, 6pm to 8pm. I would like to recognize Dr. Bernadette Ricciardelli, Diane Caldwell, Headmaster Paul D'Alleva, and Paul Teixeira, director of English Learners for their hard work. Special thank you to Kim Myles who worked hard on this project.

Walk to School Wednesdays are now in effect.

Wednesday, May 8th Kindergarten Open Houses from 2pm until 3pm.

Medford High School offered a job fair for students who were able to meet with employers, many of whom were able to interview students on the spot. Thank you to Joel Menasha for organizing this event.

Retta Smith, our district nutritionist, and some students from CCSR set up an outdoor classroom.

AP Calculus students in Barbara Chyen's class engaged in an exciting project calculating the volume of a solid with a known cross section. Photos can be found on our blog.

This week begins Ramadan for our Muslim residents, Happy Ramadan.

CCSR held their annual end of year dinner, which I attended at the Bistro.

I attended the CAS-IT Italian Day event. It was a wonderful learning experience.

Thank you to the West Medford Community Center for inviting me to their annual legislative breakfast.

Ms. Van der Kloot - I want to give a shout out to Nicole Chin, who was the student who organized the dinner. Everybody had a great time and it was great to celebrate the students. I would like to discuss the Middle School Lottery and what worked and what did not. How much did the CPA firm cost and was it worth it? Dr. Ricciardelli - It cost \$1,100. Dr. Edouard-Vincent - Having gone through it this first time, I think we can do it independently in the future. Ms. Van der Kloot - Is there another way? Dr. Edouard-Vincent - For this year, this was what we could do to take a first step. I have heard the suggestion that we have all sixth graders in one location and split up seventh and eighth grade, a more robust feasibility study. We are committed to a feasibility study and looking at the footprint of both schools with a cost benefit analysis. Ms. Van der Kloot - The reason we built the schools the way we did was for funding from the state. Years have passed and it is time to take a look at it.

Recommendation to Approve Donation to Andrews Middle School Drama Club - Diane Caldwell - Thank you to the Fitzpatrick family for this donation. Motion to accept offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Ms DiBenedetto.

Roll call vote

6 - Affirmative

1 - Absent: Mayor Burke

Motion passes.

Follow-Up Report on Fundraising Organizations and Student Activity Accounts - Emily Lazzaro and Mary Jo Petrone - This report was requested for student activities and this is updated as of this past Friday, we are happy to answer questions. Ms. DiBenedetto - What about rentals of facilities and community schools and Friends Of organizations? Ms. Lazzaro - The rental question should be directed to Community Schools. Mr. Ruseau - We lack a district-wide master schedule or facilities rental procedure. Kirsteen Patterson - We do actually have district-wide scheduling. It may be a communication issue and we might need to work with building principals. Mr. Ruseau - There is no single calendar that I can find. Ms. Patterson - We can communicate with people who are posting these events. Ms. Van der Kloot - We have a few issues together here.

Condolences: Ellen Gay, John Bosnyak, Anne Maloney.

Motion to enter executive session offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Mr. Ruggiero.
9:27pm